

Please Sir Give ME MORE

Ministers present their wishlist to the finance minister and jostle for fiscal space to get higher allocations

| By Nivedita Mukherjee |

The elections are over, results are in, and the verdict is clear. The people of India who voted for stability and reforms now expect the Government to lead the country back on to the path of impressive growth. As the countdown to the first full Budget of the new UPA Government begins, the expectations are high, the air of anticipation more charged, and the Government's sense of the need to fulfil the thumping mandate more pronounced. Not surprising, against a backdrop of the worst-ever global financial crisis whose ripple effects in India have left millions jobless, exporters impoverished and the great Indian middle class bereft of appetite for consumption. The result: the UPA's ministers want the Budget to address issues that dog their sectors.

Team Pranab Mukherjee thus has its job cut out. Script a Budget that would steer investments in agriculture and industry, pour funds into infrastructure development and put money in the hands of people so that they can drive up demand for houses

or automobiles. But the challenge lies in finding the money to bankroll the plans of the ministries. With fiscal deficit at 5 per cent of GDP, there is not much room for sops. All ministers want to be seen as the messiahs of change and want to drive the fastest recovery in their sectors with the right incentives. From a bailout for airlines to a stimulus for exporters, from higher allocations for power and building roads to lower interest rates on housing—the mad scramble for a share of the budgetary pie has begun.

The worst-hit sectors feel that they should get priority. Take Minister for Civil Aviation Praful Patel who dreamt of

**FINANCE
MINISTER PRANAB
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